# Agentic AI as a Copilot to Reduce MTTD and MTTR During Incident Response: A Systematic Literature Review

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***Abstract*—Incident response (IR) in modern IT operations is constrained by two time-based indicators — Mean Time to Detect (MTTD) and Mean Time to Recovery (MTTR) — and by the cognitive load imposed on operations teams (SRE, NOC, SOC) by alert fatigue and telemetry complexity. Agentic AI systems, which combine Large Language Models (LLMs) with planning, memory, tool use, and human supervision, are increasingly proposed as *copilots* for these teams. This article reports a systematic literature review (SLR), conducted under the guidelines of Kitchenham et al. and the PRISMA 2020 flow, that consolidates the evidence on Agentic AI copilots for incident response, with cognitive-load reduction treated as a complementary outcome. Across two update cycles over a foundational corpus, 89 candidate studies (2020–2026) were identified and screened, 61 were assessed in full text by *three independent evaluators* (inter-rater agreement 90.2–91.8% per pair; Fleiss' $\kappa = 0.53$; 53/61 unanimous decisions), and 53 studies were included. The review makes three findings. First, no included study measures MTTD *and* MTTR nominally against its own baseline in production: the single study that reports nominal MTTR does so in a proof of concept, compared against the literature, with results unfavorable to the proposed agent. Second, the published evidence is dominated by detection proxies (accuracy, F1, AUC) and qualitative claims, while secondary sources report dramatic operational gains (e.g., MTTR reduced from 8 hours to 90 minutes) that remain unverified by primary experiments. Third, direct measurement of operator cognitive load exists in adjacent domains (neuroergonomics, control rooms, maritime operations) but has never been combined with an agentic copilot in IT incident response. These gaps jointly define a concrete research agenda: field evaluations of agentic copilots instrumented for nominal MTTD/MTTR with their own baselines and validated cognitive-load instruments.**

***Index Terms*—Agentic AI, AIOps, incident response, LLM agents, MTTD, MTTR, cognitive load, multi-agent systems, systematic literature review, SOC.**

## I. Introduction

MODERN IT operations teams face a structural asymmetry: distributed, cloud-native systems generate telemetry at machine speed, while detection, diagnosis, and remediation remain bounded by human cognition. The operational cost of this asymmetry is captured by two indicators — *Mean Time to Detect* (MTTD) and *Mean Time to Recovery* (MTTR) — and by a human cost that is harder to see on dashboards: alert fatigue and sustained cognitive load on SRE, NOC, and SOC personnel. Industry reports cited in the corpus place average breach identification and containment at 277 days (204 to detect, 73 to contain) [1], while SOC analysts discard the majority of alerts as false positives.

*Agentic AI* — AI systems that pursue goals with some degree of autonomy by combining LLM-based reasoning with planning, memory, tool use, and human oversight [2], [3] — has been proposed as a new operating model for incident response: not full automation, but a *copilot* that perceives, reasons, acts, and learns alongside the human operator. The promise is threefold: earlier detection (MTTD), faster remediation (MTTR), and a lighter day-to-day workload for operations teams.

This article asks whether the published evidence supports that promise. It reports a systematic literature review (SLR) conducted under the guidelines of Kitchenham et al. [4], with study selection reported in the PRISMA 2020 format [5], scope delimited with the PICOC framework [6], and quality assessment mirroring the DARE criteria [7]. The review was executed as an *update review* in two cycles over a foundational corpus of 19 studies, processing 89 candidate studies in total, and — unusually for SLRs in this area — every full-text assessment was performed independently by *three evaluators*, with inter-rater reliability quantified by Cohen's [8] and Fleiss' [9] kappa.

The contributions are:

1) a consolidated corpus of 53 studies (2020–2026) on Agentic AI for incident response and adjacent IT operations, organized in a taxonomy of agentic paradigms (Section IV);
2) triple-verified bibliometrics (OpenAlex, Crossref, Scopus) and an internal cross-citation map of the corpus (52 citing edges) identifying its conceptual hubs;
3) evidence synthesis showing that **no study measures MTTD and MTTR nominally with its own baseline in production** (Section IV-C), and a catalogue of the proxies actually used;
4) a bridge to the human-factors literature: a cluster of studies that measure operator cognitive load directly — yet never in combination with an agentic copilot in IT incident response (Section IV-D);
5) a methodological contribution: a fully reproducible three-rater protocol whose residual disagreements (8 of 61 decisions) are all traceable to three explicit protocol rules rather than to content interpretation (Section IV-F).

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## II. Background and Related Work

### A. From AIOps to Agentic AI

AIOps applies machine learning to IT operations data — logs, metrics, traces — for anomaly detection, root cause analysis (RCA), and remediation. Surveys in the corpus trace its evolution from knowledge-based automation to ML pipelines [10] and, after 2023, to LLM-centered architectures [11]. The agentic turn adds goal pursuit under governance: taxonomies distinguish *AI agents* (tool-using, single-task) from *Agentic AI* (multi-step autonomy with planning and memory) [2], and reference surveys map its technologies, applications, and societal implications [3], [12], [13].

### B. Incident response and its metrics

Incident response spans detection, triage, diagnosis (RCA), remediation, and post-incident learning. MTTD and MTTR are its canonical outcome metrics; alert fatigue and operator cognitive load are its canonical human costs. In security operations, the same cycle appears as SOC triage and SOAR playbooks [14], [1]. A persistent finding of this review — anticipated here — is that primary studies rarely instrument these nominal metrics, reporting detection-quality proxies instead.

### C. The foundational corpus and its hubs

The present review updates a foundational SLR (19 studies, P01–P19). Cross-citation analysis over the full corpus (Section IV-E) shows that three foundational surveys act as conceptual hubs — [3] (7 internal citations), [2] (6), and [15] (5) — confirming their role as the definitional substrate on which the empirical studies build.

## III. Review Method

The protocol follows Kitchenham et al. [4]: planning (PICOC, research questions, search string), conducting (search, screening, quality assessment, extraction), and reporting (this article). All protocol artifacts — prompts, extraction sheets, per-study assessments, and machine-readable result tables — are version-controlled in the research repository.

### A. PICOC

Table I shows the PICOC delimitation [6]. A protocol rule (v1.1.0), introduced after a three-rater calibration of the PICOC extraction itself, requires that *Comparison* be recorded as declared **only when the study executes an empirical comparison against a concrete baseline**; purely conceptual contrasts (e.g., "Agentic AI vs. traditional AI" in prose) are recorded as not applicable. This rule removed 100% of the inter-rater divergences observed in the Comparison field.

TABLE I
PICOC delimitation of the review.

| Element | Definition |
|---|---|
| Population | Complex software systems and the teams operating them (SRE, NOC, SOC); microservices; IT operations pipelines. |
| Intervention | Agentic AI as copilot or autonomous agent: LLM-based agents, multi-agent systems, LLM4AIOps, the perceive–reason–act–learn loop. |
| Comparison | Traditional automation, non-agentic AIOps, or human baselines — *declared only with an executed empirical baseline* (rule v1.1.0). |
| Outcomes | MTTD, MTTR, observability, detection accuracy, alert fatigue, and operator cognitive load (complementary outcome). |
| Context | The incident-response life cycle in IT operations and cybersecurity; HITL/HOTL supervision; production vs. simulation. |

### B. Research questions

- **RQ1 (Context/Definitions).** Which capabilities and autonomy levels (planning, memory, tool use, human supervision) characterize Agentic AI, and how do they affect decision-making in complex environments?
- **RQ2 (Engineering/Architecture).** Which architectures and mechanisms (orchestration, memory, tools, guardrails, observability) sustain Agentic AI in production?
- **RQ3 (Evidence/Benefits).** Which quantitative and qualitative evidence reports benefits, and which metrics are used (response time, decision quality, operational load), especially in incident response?
- **RQ4 (Challenges/Ethics).** Which risks and challenges (security, robustness, governance, accountability) limit responsible use in critical systems?
- **RQ5 (Gaps).** Which gaps and future directions (evaluation/benchmarking, threat models, governance, observability, alignment) are identified?

### C. Search and identification

The search string was derived from the cross-study PICOC synthesis as two mandatory blocks — *Intervention* (agentic AI, LLM agents, multi-agent systems, AIOps copilots) AND *Context/Population* (incident response, IT operations, SRE/NOC/SOC, observability) — with *Outcomes* deliberately optional, since only 1 of 38 calibration studies named MTTD/MTTR in its metadata. The string was calibrated against the known corpus and validated by real execution on OpenAlex (≈49,700 records) and on the Scopus Search API (12,783 records, 2020+, English), achieving 13/14 recall of the included calibration set in both engines with the same single miss. Candidate identification combined assisted search (cycle 1: three independent LLM assistants, ≈51 raw records) and author-driven discovery (cycle 2: 49 candidates). Backward/forward snowballing is mandatory in the protocol because one included study is not indexed by Scopus and one is not retrieved by the main query.

### D. Selection criteria

Inclusion required: publication year ≥2020 (I1); an identifiable peer-reviewed venue (I2); venue quality thresholds (I3–I4, national Qualis A1–A2 and SJR Q1–Q2); at least one citation in any of three indexers, with a recency exception for papers younger than 12 months (I5); and thematic adherence

TABLE II
SELECTION FLOW ACROSS THE TWO UPDATE CYCLES.

| Stage | Cycle 1 | Cycle 2 |
|---|---|---|
| Identified | ≈51 → 21 unique | 49 |
| Screened | 20 (–1 duplicate) | 49 |
| Excluded at screening | 2 (E1) | 27 (E2=19, E3=8) |
| Assessed in full text | 18 | 22 |
| Excluded after assessment | 4 | 2 |
| **Included** | **14** | **20** |
| Corpus (cumulative) | 33 (19+14) | **53** (33+20) |

— an *agentic* approach in the *IR/AIOps/SOC* domain (I6). Exclusion criteria: sub-threshold venue strata (E1), non-agentic approaches (E2), out-of-domain studies (E3), duplicates (E4), and non-peer-reviewed material (E5). A dated protocol amendment in cycle 2 allowed four candidates outside the I3/I4 strata to proceed to full-text assessment *with a mandatory stratum caveat*; the amendment is itself part of the audit trail and, notably, is the root cause of three of the eight residual inter-rater divergences (Section IV-F).

### E. Selection flow (PRISMA)

Fig. 1 shows the PRISMA 2020 flow of both update cycles over the foundational corpus, and Table II summarizes the stage counts side by side. In cycle 2, thematic exclusion (E2/E3) was applied already at screening, because a full-text PICOC extraction of all 49 candidates (one reading agent per PDF, consolidated and audited) provided per-study evidence before assessment — each screening exclusion cites that evidence and a cycle-1 precedent.

The 53-study corpus comprises the 19 foundational studies, 14 cycle-1 inclusions, and 20 cycle-2 inclusions; seven of these are secondary "foundational-conditional" studies [16], [17], [18], [13], [19], [20], [1] that migrate to background material if the protocol is restricted to primary studies (primary corpus: 46).

### F. Quality assessment and extraction

Each assessed study received: (i) a verified bibliometric record (DOI, venue, year, and citation counts kept *per source* — OpenAlex, Crossref, Scopus — never summed, with "not indexed" distinguished from zero); (ii) an RQ-coverage score (RQ1–RQ5, each rated fully/partially/not answered = 1.0/0.5/0.0, max 5.0); (iii) a DARE-style quality score (QA1 clear objectives, QA2 replicable methodology, QA3 solid evidence base, QA4 coherent conclusions; max 4.0; bands High $\geq$3.0, Medium 1.5–2.5, Low $<$1.5); and (iv) an 11-field structured extraction sheet with per-claim evidence anchors (section/page). The 19 foundational studies were re-assessed retroactively under the same rubric — without re-opening their inherited inclusion — so that all 61 assessments are directly comparable.

### G. Three-evaluator protocol

Every full-text assessment was executed independently by three LLM-based evaluators (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini) from the same written prompt and PDF. Agreement was computed on collapsed include/exclude decisions with Cohen's $\kappa$ per pair [8] and Fleiss' $\kappa$ overall [9]. Results are reported in Section IV-F.

TABLE III
TAXONOMY OF THE INCLUDED CORPUS (N=53; REPRESENTATIVE STUDIES).

| Paradigm | Studies |
|---|---|
| LLM multi-agent (RCA/SOC) | [23], [14], [24], [25], [31] |
| Single-agent LLM copilot (+RAG) | [36], [28], [29], [30] |
| Closed-loop remediation agents | [37], [26], [38] |
| SLM/compact-model agents | [27] |
| MAS/RL and self-organization (non-LLM) | [39], [40] |
| Conceptual agentic frameworks (AIOps/PdM) | [41], [42] |
| AI-assisted SIEM / alert triage | [43] |
| Foundational surveys (agents, LLM-sec, AIOps) | [11], [2], [3], [15], [12], [10], [16], [17], [18], [13], [19], [20], [1] |
| Human factors & instruments | [44], [32], [33], [34], [35] |

## IV. RESULTS

### A. Corpus overview and taxonomy

Table III organizes the 53 included studies by agentic paradigm. Three observations structure the corpus. First, the *foundational layer* is dominated by definitional surveys [2], [3], [12], [13] and governance/trust reviews [21], [22]; these answer RQ1/RQ4/RQ5 strongly but contribute no empirical benefit evidence. Second, the *empirical core* is concentrated in cycle 1: multi-agent LLM systems for RCA and SOC [23], [14], [24], [25], closed-loop remediation [26], and a small-language-model agent for ICT operations [27] — the methodological high-water marks of the corpus (QA $4.0/4.0$). Third, cycle 2 adds the copilot pattern proper — RAG-based security copilots [28], [29], [30] and SOC hyper-automation [31] — plus a *human-factors cluster* absent from earlier cycles [32], [33], [34], [35].

### B. RQ coverage and quality

RQ coverage shifted between cycles in a telling way. In cycle 1 (18 assessed; mean RQ score 3.83, mean QA 3.50) the systematic gap was **RQ4** (ethics and governance: only 4/18 fully answered). In cycle 2 (22 assessed; mean RQ 3.16, mean QA 2.75; zero unconditional inclusions) the gap moved to **RQ3/QA3**: abundant conceptual contribution with scarce empirical benefit evidence. The retroactive assessment of the foundational studies (mean RQ 3.66, mean QA 2.53) shows the same profile — high RQ coverage by surveys, low QA for lack of their own validation. Across all 61 assessments the pattern is stable: *the literature is conceptually rich and empirically thin precisely on the benefit claims that motivate it*.

### C. Evidence on MTTD and MTTR

This is the review's central result. After screening 89 candidates and assessing 61 in full text across two cycles:

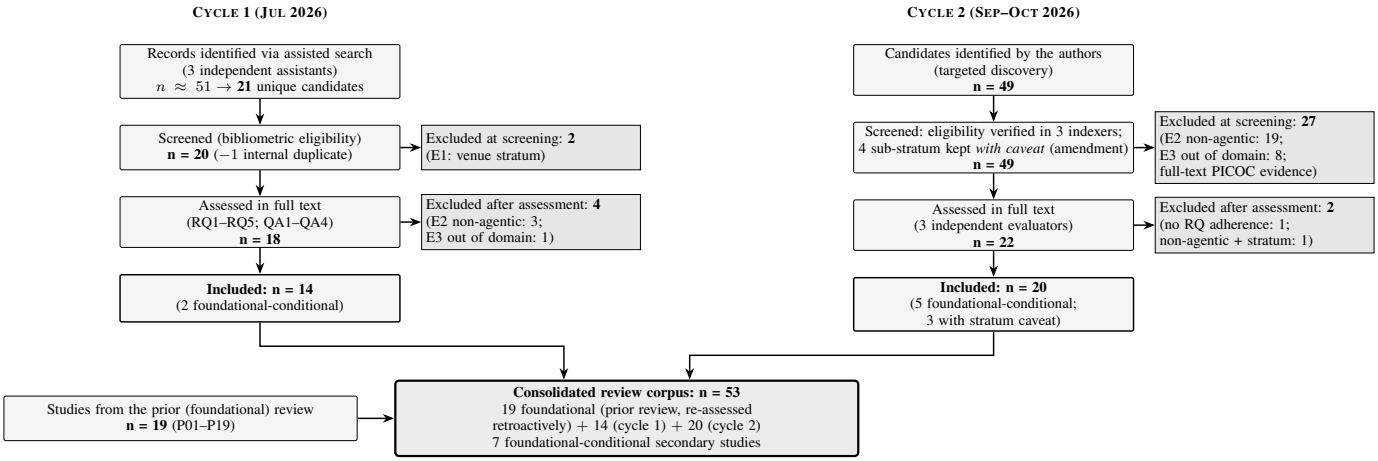



Fig. 1. PRISMA 2020 flow of the two update cycles over the foundational corpus (adapted for a review update). Cycle-2 screening exclusions are anchored in a full-text PICOC extraction of all 49 candidates; the stratum amendment is dated and auditable in the protocol.

- **No study measures MTTD and MTTR nominally against its own baseline in production.**
- **One study reports nominal MTTR.** The SOC hyper-automation agent of [31] reports per-phase remediation times of ≈1–1.5 min in a proof of concept (one use case, SSH brute force), compared against *literature values* for a commercial security copilot (≈30–45 s) — i.e., no own baseline, and a result *unfavorable* to the proposed agent. The authors' candor is valuable; the evidence level is PoC.
- **Secondary evidence reports dramatic gains.** The SOC survey [1] relays primary reports of MTTR reduced from 8 hours to 90 minutes, 98% of alerts auto-triaged with containment under 5 minutes, and a 277-day industry detect-and-contain baseline. None of these numbers is reproduced by a primary study in the corpus.
- **Proxies dominate.** The strongest quantified operational outcomes are proxies: a 74–84% global alert-volume reduction in a national SOC [43]; operator reaction time falling from ≈276 s to ≈107 s with decision support in a control-room experiment (Wilcoxon $p < 0.01$) [35]; end-to-end incident-report latency of 2.9–11.6 s with 0.3 s pre-detection [30]; and copilot answer quality (BERTScore ≈85–87%) without timing [29]. Detection studies report accuracy/F1/AUC only.

The gap is therefore not merely "few studies": it is a structural mismatch between the motivating claim of the field (time-metric reduction) and its measurement practice (detection proxies and qualitative assertions). The claim that agentic copilots reduce MTTD and MTTR is, as of 2026, *plausible but unverified by primary evidence*.

### D. Cognitive load: the complementary outcome

The second gap concerns the review's bonus outcome. Within IT incident response, no corpus study measures operator cognitive load directly; alert fatigue appears as an alert-volume proxy [43]. Direct measurement exists in adjacent domains, and cycle 2 deliberately retained this cluster (with stratum caveats under the protocol amendment): neuroergonomic foundations of mental workload and engagement [32]; a multimodal workload database with classification AUC up to 0.998 and NASA-TLX ground truth [34]; and a human experiment in which an AI decision-support system improved control-room operator performance [35]. The corpus also offers a validated usability instrument for conversational agents (BUS-15) [33]. The intersection — *agentic copilot* × *IT incident response* × *measured cognitive load* — is empty. Together with Section IV-C, this defines the experimental agenda that motivates the authors' ongoing work: a copilot evaluated in the field with nominal MTTD/MTTR against its own baseline *and* validated workload instruments (NASA-TLX; BUS-15 for the conversational interface).

### E. Cross-citation structure of the corpus

Internal citation analysis (triple-checked: OpenAlex `referenced_works`, Crossref reference lists, Scopus `REF()` by title; union of 52 citing edges) shows a coherent field rather than a bag of papers. The hubs are the definitional surveys — [3] (7 internal citations), [2] (6), [15] (5) — followed by the AIOps/MLOps and log-anomaly surveys [10], [45] (3 each). The most connected citer is the multi-agent SOC system of [14] (7 outgoing edges, five of them to cycle-2 candidates), and cycle-2 studies cite back into the corpus ([1]→[37], [28]; [31]→[46], [29]), evidencing that the two cycles sample one evolving conversation. Source-specific quirks are material for reproducibility: Scopus resolves references by *title*, not DOI; one open-access venue is not indexed there at all; and preprint DOIs can split citation identity across sources (handled here by alias resolution).

### F. Inter-rater reliability

Table IV reports agreement over the 61 collapsed include/exclude decisions. Pairwise agreement is 90.2–91.8% ($\kappa$ 0.51–0.57); Fleiss' $\kappa = 0.53$; **53/61 decisions are unanimous**, including all 19 foundational re-assessments and three unanimous exclusions. The $\kappa$ values are deflated by prevalence (89.6% of all verdicts are "include"), so the substantive reading

TABLE IV
INTER-RATER AGREEMENT ON INCLUDE/EXCLUDE DECISIONS (N=61).

| | **A×B** | **A×C** | **B×C** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Agreement | 90.2% | 91.8% | 91.8% |
| Cohen's $\kappa$ | 0.57 | 0.51 | 0.51 |

Fleiss' $\kappa$ (three raters): **0.53**; unanimous decisions: **53/61**.

is the nature of the eight divergences: *all eight are protocol-rule divergences, none is a content divergence* — in every case the three evaluators' scores agree and only the consequence rule differs. They fall into exactly three families: (A) the treatment of non-agentic secondary studies (2 cases); (B) whether the cycle-2 stratum amendment binds, which one evaluator — applying the strict criterion — did not honor (3 cases); and (C) domain/stratum boundary calls (3 cases). Registering these three rules in the protocol would eliminate all residual divergence. Mean absolute score differences are small (RQ 0.44–0.63; QA 0.31–0.63), with systematic evaluator profiles: one strict on protocol and quality, one lenient, one intermediate with the hardest thematic cut.

## V. DISCUSSION

### A. What the evidence supports — and what it does not

The corpus firmly supports three claims: (i) a consolidated conceptual model of Agentic AI for operations (autonomy levels, orchestration, guardrails, HITL) [2], [3], [12], [13]; (ii) technical feasibility of agentic RCA, triage, and remediation at prototype level, with strong detection-quality results [27], [26], [23], [14], [24], [25]; and (iii) a well-articulated risk and governance agenda [21], [47], [22], [15]. It does *not* yet support the headline operational claim: the MTTD/MTTR reduction attributed to agentic copilots rests on secondary reports and qualitative assertions (Section IV-C). Reviewers and practitioners should treat vendor-scale numbers (e.g., 8h $\rightarrow$ 90min MTTR) as hypotheses to be tested, not established effects.

### B. Why the measurement gap persists

Three corpus-visible causes: production access (most studies evaluate on public datasets or testbeds; industrial deployments are rare and rarely instrumented for time metrics); benchmark culture (detection communities optimize F1/AUC, which do not compose into end-to-end time outcomes); and the autonomy–accountability tension (studies that do deploy agents constrain them to low-risk actions, making time gains modest and hard to attribute). The one nominal measurement available [31] being *unfavorable* to the agent is a useful counterweight to publication bias.

### C. Implications for research and practice

For researchers, the agenda is concrete: field studies that instrument MTTD and MTTR nominally, pre/post or A/B against the team's own baseline, with the agentic copilot as the treatment; and that pair time metrics with validated human-factors instruments (NASA-TLX [34], BUS-15 [33]) to test the cognitive-load "bonus" directly. For practitioners, the corpus supports piloting copilots on triage and report drafting (where latency and quality evidence exists [29], [30]) under HITL governance [48], [44], while treating full-loop autonomous remediation as experimental [26], [31].

### D. Methodological lessons for LLM-assisted SLRs

Two findings generalize beyond this topic. First, three independent LLM evaluators under one written protocol achieve substantial-level agreement, and their residual disagreements expose *protocol ambiguities, not model randomness* — a cheap and effective audit mechanism. Second, protocol amendments must be placed in the normative body of the evaluation prompt, not in its input metadata: the one evaluator that missed the stratum amendment read it as advisory, producing three of the eight divergences.

## VI. THREATS TO VALIDITY

**Selection.** Assisted identification (LLM search in cycle 1, author-driven discovery in cycle 2) may bias candidate coverage; this is mitigated by dual-engine string validation (13/14 recall on OpenAlex and Scopus), mandatory snowballing, and full audit trails, but a database-exhaustive census was not the goal of the update design. **Strata criteria.** Venue-quality thresholds (I3–I4) use a national classification (Qualis) alongside SJR; the dated amendment that retained four sub-threshold studies is explicit, and all conclusions in Sections IV-C–IV-D hold with those studies removed. **Evaluator validity.** All three raters are LLM systems; they are independent of each other but share potential model-family biases. The unanimity of the core corpus (87%), the protocol-only nature of divergences, and per-claim evidence anchors in every assessment mitigate — but do not eliminate — this threat; human adjudication of the three open protocol rules is the planned next step. **Bibliometric sources.** Citation counts are kept per source and never summed; source quirks (title-based reference resolution, unindexed venues, preprint DOI splits, API service-level limits) are documented in the audit trail.

## VII. CONCLUSION

This SLR consolidated 53 studies (2020–2026) on Agentic AI as a copilot for incident response, assessed by three independent evaluators with substantial agreement. The field has matured conceptually — shared definitions, reference architectures, governance agendas, and a coherent citation structure — and demonstrates prototype-level feasibility of agentic detection, RCA, and remediation. Yet its motivating claim remains unmeasured: no primary study reports nominal MTTD and MTTR against its own production baseline, and operator cognitive load has never been measured in the presence of an agentic copilot in IT operations. The most valuable next contribution to this literature is therefore not another architecture, but a field evaluation: an agentic copilot deployed with a team, instrumented for MTTD/MTTR with its own baseline, and paired with validated workload instruments. That study is the direct continuation of this review.

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